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Abstract

This report proposes a strategy for implementing a glitch-based fault injector targeting RISC-V processors for edge AI. The glitcher module delivers timing and voltage disturbances that mimic realistic bit flips. It also targets stuck-at faults, and instruction address faults for comprehensive coverage. We integrate an FPGA-based pulse generator with a controller to achieve sub-nanosecond precision. We synchronize injections to instruction fetch or memory access events for precise fault timing. We compare the fault profile against QEMU emulation results to validate our models.

1 Introduction

This report defines a practical strategy for implementing a glitch-based fault injector targeting RISC-V processors. The glitcher will disturb the system's normal electrical behavior to introduce timing or voltage anomalies that cause logical faults. The goal is to observe fault-effects and compare them against emulated models in QEMU. This process ensures that the physical fault profile aligns with the simulated one for validation and training of LLM-based fault detection models.

Glitch injection attacks deliberately exploit timing windows in hardware components. Researchers have demonstrated that attackers can alter data or control flow by shifting clock edges or pulsing the voltage lines (Timmers et al., 2016). Although these attacks typically require physical access and precise equipment, the laboratory environment offers sufficient control for replicating them. The glitcher must reliably deliver faults that simulate realistic hardware-level disturbances encountered in edge AI deployments.

Unlike typical software-based fault injections, glitch-based methods enable low-level perturbations that trigger setup and hold time violations. This level of control helps test the vulnerability of silicon components to sudden changes in voltage or signal timing (Barenghi et al., 2012). For the project scope, the glitcher must interface cleanly with the controller hardware and Python-based injection scripts to automate both the fault delivery and logging process.

2 Target Fault Models and Justification

This section categorizes the target faults for the glitcher in terms of realism and impacts potential. The glitcher must inject only faults that can arise naturally or under realistic adversarial conditions in embedded and edge AI applications.

2.1 Bit-Flip Faults

Bit-flip faults change a single binary value in memory or a register. External radiation, electromagnetic interference (EMI), or thermal noise often cause these errors (Ziegler and Lanford, 1979). These faults appear transient but may lead to severe control failures in safety-critical systems. The glitcher can simulate these errors by pulsing data or address lines during memory access cycles.

2.2 Stuck-at Faults

Stuck-at faults fix a signal line to a permanent logical high or low value. These faults usually result from manufacturing defects or prolonged electrical stress on the line (Abramovici et al., 1994). Voltage glitching can simulate these conditions by briefly collapsing the power rail or toggling input logic. The glitcher will replicate stuck-at behavior by injecting brief but precise interference on bus or clock lines.

2.3 Instruction Corruption

Instruction corruption faults alter an instruction word in memory or during the fetch. These errors result from cache faults or instruction pipeline-disruption. Faults injected at the instruction bus level or during program memory access can reproduce this condition (Roberts, 1999). A narrow glitch targeting fetch cycles can cause misinterpretation of the instruction, leading to an exception or system halt.

2.4 Timing Violations

Timing violations occur when a signal fails to meet the setup or hold timing constraints of a flip-flop. Researchers have used clock signal distortion or delay injection to cause these faults (Fuhrman et al., 2018). A glitcher can induce timing faults by generating short pulses on the clock line or delaying signals using passive RC elements. These faults often remain undetected by error correction mechanisms, resulting in unpredictable behavior.

2.5 Address Corruption

Address corruption faults modify the intended memory address used in an operation. These may result from bus contention, degraded signal lines, or crosstalk in dense environments (Moro et al., 2013). The glitcher can simulate this class of faults by pulsing the address bus during memory fetch or load instructions. These errors can redirect execution or cause access violations.

2.6 Logic Gate Faults

Logic gate-level faults affect combinational paths within integrated circuits. These faults emerge from localized defects, particle strikes, or excessive heat. A glitcher cannot target a specific logic gate directly. However, glitching the surrounding power grid or clock timing can cause gate-level miscalculations (Barenghi et al., 2012). Such faults are the most difficult to control and verify, but the glitcher can probabilistically generate them using clock or voltage disturbances.

2.7 External Clock Glitch Injection

External clock glitch injection introduces abrupt timing errors by manipulating the system's clock source. This method requires injecting high-frequency spikes or skipped cycles into an externally supplied clock to misalign instruction execution. Researchers have used this method in controlled environments to force instruction skips, privilege escalations, or register bypasses (Dehbaoui et al., 2012).

This method assumes the target system exposes a clock interface or relies on an external oscillator, which is not always the case in real-world deployments. However, laboratory setups that emulate such exposure enable precise glitch timing with tools like the ChipWhisperer platform or custom FPGA-based clock modulators.

The glitcher can replicate this behavior by interfacing directly with the clock line using a delay-controlled waveform generator. By precisely controlling the width, amplitude, and phase offset of the clock pulse, the glitcher can inject faults at the decode or execute stages of the pipeline.

Despite its effectiveness in hardware security labs, this technique remains impractical for most edge devices deployed in sealed environments. Nevertheless, reproducing it in the lab enables benchmark comparisons against more realistic fault models and supports LLM training with rare but critical failure cases.

3 Glitcher Design Requirements

This section defines key requirements for a laboratory-grade glitcher. It details functional blocks, triggering mechanisms, timing calibration, and physical coupling methods. Each subsection describes how to construct a reproducible fault injector compatible with the Genesys ZU board.

3.1 Functional Blocks

The glitcher must contain four primary functional blocks, as shown in Fig. 1:

3.1.1 Trigger Interface

- Receives commands from the controller via UART or GPIO.
- Translates high-level injection parameters into hardware signals (Ziegler and Lanford, 1979).

3.1.2 Pulse Generator

- Creates adjustable-width pulses for voltage or clock lines.
- It also employs an FPGA-based state machine for sub-nanosecond resolution (Barenghi et al., 2012).

3.1.3 Timing Controller

- It coordinates glitch onset and duration with processor cycles.
- Uses hardware delay lines or calibrated PLL shifts (Dehbaoui et al., 2012).

3.1.4 Injection Coupler

- Interfaces directly with the target board's clock or power net.
- Utilizes MOSFET switches or analog buffers to inject disturbances (Moro et al., 2013).

These blocks must reside within a compact hardware module or FPGA mezzanine card electrically coupled to the Genesys ZU.

3.2 Triggering Logic

The trigger logic must reliably synchronize with the processor's execution cycles. The controller sends a "glitch now" signal over UART or GPIO. The glitcher decodes this packet, verifies the parameter set, and arms the pulse generator. When the next qualifying clock edge arises, the timing controller activates the pulse generator. This precise handoff ensures successful fault injection at the intended instruction fetch or memory access (Timmers et al., 2016).

The trigger sequence follows these steps:

1. Controller asserts START_INJECTION over serial.
2. Trigger Interface validates checksum and glitch mode.
3. Trigger Interface signals Timing Controller to arm.
4. Timing Controller detects upcoming clock edge.
5. Timing-Controller issues ACTIVATE_PULSE to Pulse Generator.
6. Pulse Generator creates glitch on Injection Coupler.

This deterministic flow eliminates race conditions and ensures reproducible fault windows.

3.3 Timing Precision and Calibration

The glitcher must achieve sub-nanosecond precision in pulse width and phase alignment. We adopt a two-stage calibration approach:

3.3.1 FPGA Delay Calibration

- Configure the FPGA's programmable delay lines for incrementally shifting pulse edges.
- Measure output with a high-speed oscilloscope to map configuration values to actual time delays (Barenghi et al., 2012).

3.3.2 PLL Phase-Locked Loop Tuning

- Use an external PLL to generate a slightly shifted clock for comparative timing.
- Adjust PLL phase offsets until glitch pulses consistently align with target clock edges (Fuhrman et al., 2018).

After calibration, the system maintains a look-up table correlating register settings with nanosecond delays. The controller queries this table for each injection event, guaranteeing that pulse width and offset meet the fault model specification.

3.4 Physical Coupling Methods

The glitcher must inject faults without permanently damaging the target board. We propose two coupling methods:

3.4.1 Clock Line Disturbance

- Connect the Injection Coupler directly in series with the processor's clock trace using a low-inductance connector.
- MOSFET or analog switch momentarily shorts the clock to ground, producing a skipped or duplicated clock edge (Dehbaoui et al., 2012).

3.4.2 Power Rail Pulsing

- Insert a high-speed MOSFET in series with the processor's VCC rail.
- Pulse the MOSFET gate to induce a brief undervoltage spike, simulating transient power faults (Moro et al., 2013).

Both methods require the correct decoupling capacitors and ferrite beads to limit collateral noise. Isolation resistors help prevent latch-up in adjacent circuits. Engineers must verify the board's tolerances before connecting the glitcher hardware.

4 Proposed Integration Strategy for Realistic Fault Injection on Genesys ZU

This section outlines a practical approach to implement fault injection mechanisms targeting a RISC-V softcore deployed on the Genesys ZU platform. The strategy focuses solely on fault models that are plausible in real-world automotive edge applications, particularly in safety-critical modules such as object or obstruction detection subsystems.

These faults include bit flips, stuck-at faults, instruction corruption, memory address corruption, and timing violations. Each implementation aligns with modular integration through a glitcher and external controller, forming a complete real-time validation platform.

4.1 System Architecture Overview

The testbed employs two Genesys ZU boards—one hosts the RISC-V target system, and the other handles fault injection through a glitcher circuit. The controller injects faults via clock modulation, voltage-fluctuation, or direct logic interfacing, depending on the fault type. The architecture allows hardware-in-the-loop (HIL) fault injection while maintaining timing realism.

The controller synchronizes with the target's operating clock and modifies the execution environment using glitch signals or peripheral injection. UART or SPI ensures low-latency communication between the controller and the target.

4.2 Bit Flip

Cosmic radiation and electromagnetic disturbances may flip single bits in registers or memory (Ziegler and Lanford, 1979). To simulate this, the glitcher must induce short, low-voltage pulses at the memory controller or register file during active read/write cycles. Programmable GPIOs routed to internal buses enable selective fault targeting. Fine-grain glitch width tuning allows safe injection without violating setup and hold times (Mukherjee, 2008).

4.3 Stuck-at Faults

Stuck-at faults represent permanent hardware damage or latch-up conditions (Abramovici et al., 1994). The glitcher shall assert constant high or low logic levels on internal data lines through programmable logic probes. Using Vivado's Integrated Logic Analyzer (ILA), the operator can monitor fault propagation. To ensure fault realism, the glitcher shall maintain the stuck condition across multiple clock cycles until reset or overridden by an error handler.

4.4 Instruction Corruption

Instruction corruption simulates malformed or misfetched operations due to bus noise or fetch-line degradation (Roberts, 1999). The glitcher shall inject faults during the instruction fetch phase using a time-triggered pulse mapped to the instruction memory bus. Real-time monitoring through the trace analyzer ensures the corrupt opcode replaces the fetched one without changing the PC or timing footprint. A logic sniffer or additional AXI monitor validates whether the fault reaches the decoder stage.

4.5 Memory Address Corruption

Address corruption occurs when the system accesses an unintended memory location. In safety-critical applications, this may trigger incorrect sensor data processing or stale cache accesses (Kim and Somani, 1996). The glitcher can inject a skewed address via targeted line interference or peripheral-to-memory DMA override. The controller, using a fault descriptor file, coordinates address-level corruptions during read cycles to cause observable misbehavior.

4.6 Timing Violations

Timing violations are transient faults that occur when setup and hold conditions fail under thermal or voltage stress. To simulate this, the glitcher injects variable-width clock pulses to interfere with the clock tree. Clock gating circuits inside the glitcher manipulate the effective duty cycle of the target's system clock (Nicolaidis, 1999). This simulation mimics race conditions and metastability that can arise in edge computing environments with high-frequency sampling devices, for example, LiDARs.

4.7 Fault Integration and Synchronization

All fault injections must maintain temporal precision to avoid overlapping behavior. The controller synchronizes with the target system using a hardware timestamp counter embedded in both platforms. FPGA-internal timers and interrupt lines provide deterministic timing cues. Each fault script resides on the controller board and communicates with the glitcher module via a serial peripheral interface, ensuring reusability and modularity.

4.8 Implementation Caveats and Future Adjustments

We note that this proposed strategy may evolve during initial practical hardware integration. Implementation challenges often require iterative adjustments to meet real-world timing constraints (Nicolaidis, 1999). We will document any modifications to maintain reproducibility and strict transparency (Mukherjee, 2008).

5 Conclusion

This report defined a practical framework for glitch-based fault injection in RISC-V edge AI. The proposed design integrates a standalone glitcher with an external controller and target softcore. It focuses exclusively on fault models relevant to realistic automotive obstruction detection subsystems. Bit flips, stuck-at faults, instruction corruption, and memory address errors can occur under normal conditions. Clock glitches and voltage perturbations can induce timing violations and logic gate-level disruptions (Nicolaidis, 1999; Mukherjee, 2008). This integration plans to employ an FPGA-based pulse generator and delay controller for sub-nanosecond accuracy. It ensures reproducible fault windows synchronized to RISC-V instruction fetch or memory access phases. The controller board communicates via UART or SPI to issue glitch parameters and trigger signals. Engineers must calibrate delay lines and PLL-offsets to match the target clock characteristics (Fuhrman et al., 2018). Coupling the clock and power rails requires careful layout to avoid unintended crosstalk or board damage. This strategy remains adaptable, as the actual setup may change during initial hardware integration. We will update design parameters and document all changes for reproducibility and academic transparency (Mukherjee, 2008).

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